IN

terms of personality, Vijay Shekhar Sharma, founder of digital payments start-up Paytm, and Byju Raveendran, co-founder of edtech start-up BYJU'S, could not be more different. Sharma, 45, is outgoing and aggressive, and wears his emotions on his sleeve, be it in office or outside. Raveendran, 44, on the other hand, is said to be shy and somewhat of an introvert, a man of few words, except when he gets down to doing what he loves the most—teaching.

However, there is plenty the two have in common, too. Both grew up in small towns, went to local schools and learnt English on the fly—one by memorising rock music lyrics and the other by listening to cricket commentary. From humble beginnings, both built formidable companies that rapidly became unicorns and they the poster boys of their respective businesses. Sharma, in digital payments, with 330 million digital wallets in his firm Paytm's payments bank, 118 million customers who took Rs 15,500 crore loans through its tie-ups and 60 million users for its FASTag service that allows digital payments at toll booths across the country. One97 Communications, the parent company of Paytm, posted revenues of Rs 6,028 crore in FY23 and had a market capitalisation of Rs 1.1 lakh crore at the time of its listing on the Bombay Stock Exchange on November 18, 2021, via an IPO (initial public offering).

Raveendran, meanwhile, made his mark in online education, where he built an enterprise that was valued at $22 billion (Rs 1.8 lakh crore) in 2022, earned revenues of Rs 5,298 crore in FY22 and had 120 million students and 600 offline centres. Sharma featured in *Forbes*' World Billionaires list in 2022 with a net worth of $1.2 billion (Rs 9,950 crore); Raveendran had debuted on the list two years before, in 2020, with a fortune of $1.8 billion (Rs 14,900 crore).

The billionaire entrepreneurs hogged the limelight as torchbearers of a vibrant start-up ecosystem in the country, characterised by a crop of young go-getters who defied conventional rules to float companies that, more often than not, disrupted businesses. Both of them thrived on the back of black swan events. Sharma's nascent payments bank, Paytm, flourished as Prime Minister Narendra Modi's demonetisation move in 2016 sucked

Paytm

VIJAY SHEKHAR SHARMA, 45

Founder, Paytm

ENTERPRISING CHILDHOOD

Grew up in Aligarh, UP, with six siblings; their father was a teacher. At his Hindi-medium school, many of Sharma's classmates came barefoot. "I never wanted to go back to that world," he says





Devised a Hindi-English dictionary to learn English, comparing the NCERT book with the UP board textbook in Hindi to figure out, for example, what 'momentum' or 'distance' meant

Later, at the Delhi College of Engineering (he read electronics and communications), lyrics from Pink Floyd, The Doors, U2 and Coldplay become his doorway to learning English. "I'd learn the lyrics, play them back in my head in a loop...in them, I found the unlikeliest of